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Ray Ricker

Dr. Ray Ricker has led a distinguished career in both classical and jazz world. He is a saxophonist, clarinetist, composer, arranger, and educator. He is now retired from the Eastman School of Music.

Dr. Ricker was interviewed via Zoom on January 27, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and it's a privilege to be speaking with Doctor Ray Ricker this afternoon. Welcome.

RR: Thanks, Monk. Glad to talk with you.

MR: I had to practice this a little bit, that you are a classical and jazz performer, a music educator, a composer, arranger, and author, music contractor, and perhaps the quintessential example of a complete musician.

RR: Well I do do a lot of different things, but yeah.

MR: Did you have, as a teenager, what I'll call an aha moment? An epiphany of any sort that you remember that really directed your career path?

RR: Well I always liked to practice and so my parents didn't have to bug me about that. And there were a couple of things along the way. I got principal clarinet in the Colorado — I'm from Denver — so in the Colorado All-State and that was a big one, and it kind of moved me on, and I went to the University of Denver, I lived at home. It's a good school and I had a good clarinet teacher and a good jazz band. In fact we were sent in 1965 to Asia, we were sent for three months on a State Department tour. And that was the result that we won the Notre Dame Jazz Festival the previous year. That's when it was really a contest and the State Department people were there. And they, you know they liked the band, they also liked that the band was diverse and so yeah, three months touring Asia. It was a great, great trip.

MR: Was the jazz group considered a part of the music department at that time? Because I know when I was at Fredonia in the late 60s we had a fine jazz group but it was mostly student-run and sometimes hard to get a space to perform in. They had an arm's length sort of relationship with it.

RR: Yeah, well yes this was, we got credit for it and it had an outside director. It wasn't student run. And there weren't many places in the U.S. or probably in the world at that time that they gave credit, and that was sort of a big deal. North Texas State was one and us, University of Denver, and then some of the big ten schools around that time, I remember Michigan State had a good band and they rehearsed as part of the curriculum.

But really jazz education was in its infancy at that time and to play in the big band was just sort of the first step.

MR: Yes. Were you one of the players that the director might be able to point to and say, "You got it, I need an improvised solo here"?

RR: Yeah I was one of those guys, yeah. I started out on clarinet and I always sort of kept the two tracks separate, you know I played clarinet and did all the legit stuff, the classical stuff, and at age 16 I picked up the saxophone and I remember five weeks later I played my first gig, it was New Year's Eve.

MR: That was my first gig too.

RR: Yeah. And the rest is history.

MR: And you got to play "Auld Lang Syne" for the first time, I wonder if you used the Guy Lombardo vibrato?

RR: I was playing second tenor someplace so I probably did, just follow the lead guy.

MR: Did you feel, can you remember what you made that night?

RR: You know I remember even a little after that, in college, we would get in our cars and we would drive to Goodland, Kansas or Scottsbluff, Nebraska, or Cheyenne, Wyoming or sometimes Laramie, Wyoming. You know we'd drive there for fifteen bucks, you know? It took us all — you know, we'd go there, we left in the afternoon, play the gig, come back at night, get home around, you know, five or six in the morning. It was crazy.

MR: It sure was but it's wonderful that we didn't think it was crazy at that time. I mean we might have sort of complained about it but still there's nothing like that feeling I guess. Can you remember what your repertoire would have consisted of for those gigs? This would have been around when?

RR: It would be in the latter 60s. Well no, it could be early, in high school I was there in 1960. So yeah the repertoire we played out of the "Combo Ork" Books I think they were called. And the instrumentation worked on about — for about any number of players that you had. And then there were some — I can't remember the publishers you know. But there wasn't a lot of music for us to play. In fact by the time I got to college you know you had to, if you wanted to be competitive in these contests that we went to, or the festivals, you know you had to have some good charts. And luckily our director knew some people in Las Vegas and they would supply us with some charts, some good stuff you know, and some Basie things too. And so that's how we got our repertoire there. But just as far as high school stuff, just buying things off the shelf I mean I think bands are still playing some of that music you know.

MR: Yes. In those times it was AM radio played almost anything you could imagine, but what would the group have done if someone came up, put twenty bucks in the tip jar and said,

"Play some Sinatra"? And if you didn't know any did you have the wherewithal that you could fake it?

RR: Yeah we probably could — not all of us you know but I mean a quartet could, could play the tunes. Because that was one of the things we did was to start learning tunes and we played combo gigs, you know, with maybe just one horn and a rhythm section, or sometimes two horns, but mainly just one. And you know we called them dance gigs, and so it was mainly just learning tunes, the tunes of the day, Broadway tunes, standards, and having that repertoire of things to do, you know, things to play.

MR: Well I'm going to leapfrog a few decades. Is learning tunes for the current jazz student as important as it was back then? The reason I'm asking is partly technology that a student now can have hundreds of tunes on their phones or on their iPad, and it's been my experience that they seem less inclined to memorize things.

RR: I don't know. The standard tunes, it's sort of like if you're playing classical clarinet let's say, you still study Mozart, you know and Weber, and older composers. And the standard tunes are sort of a repertoire that I know our students at Eastman develop and work on. But you know they don't stay stuck in playing standard tunes. They are also moving into their own thing, and using the information and the skills that they develop you know as playing by ear and learning these different standards. They apply that to their compositions. So there's sort of a couple of different tracks there. There's the tunes you would play a dance job, that's what we called them okay? And then there's the jazz tunes, which were different. But you could fake it a little bit. There was some crossover ones like "The Girl from Ipanema" was one of those tunes that would cross. Or we would even, you know, play "Giant Steps" as a rumba. This is after things had been livened up a little bit at the party, and you know, you could slide something like that in in the middle of "Besame Mucho" or something.

MR: Yes.

RR: As a medley.

MR: And you could always play a nice shuffle blues and get people on the dance floor that way and just sort of get to blow on that.

RR: Oh yeah. Definitely.

MR: Yeah. Was there a particular point where you made the decision about music as your livelihood or did it just evolve, like this is an obvious thing for me?

RR: It sort of evolved but around my junior year in high school I went to All-State band and my friends were there also, the seniors that were a year older than me. And yeah, they were going, being music majors, and they were going to the University of Denver and they were getting good scholarships and that's because the band director had money to

him, and he also started giving me things that the college kids didn't want to do. You know there was a little pep band, a Dixieland band that played for all the hockey games. And it was right above the net you know, one of the nets. And we played the fight song or whatever it was you know and we'd play a little bit before the thing started and we'd play during time outs and stuff like that. And so I had that as a gig. And it was, you know my band director gave to me, which was kind of cool. I was playing with college guys and I was playing clarinet in this group. And then he also, I ended up playing a show there once, you know, a Broadway show that they were staging. And so yeah, he was recruiting me that way and it was great you know. And so that's why I went to school there. So I figured you know, music was the best thing I could do. Because I had no interest in anything else. And I didn't work very hard at anything else. I just mainly practiced. And you know read about music and just sort of lived that kind of thing.

MR: If you had gone out to a record store about that time when you were playing the hockey rink gig, what might you have purchased as far as non-classical music?

RR: Non-classical. I remember pretty much my first one I got was a ten inch 33-1/3 — no a ten — or it was the small one, not the — maybe the big one was the ten inch. I don't know. But this was the smaller one. And it was Horace Silver. And it had four tunes on it you know. And that was the first one I got. After that I joined the Columbia Record Archive you know, the whatever, the one where you got a record every month and they just came. And sometimes you got to choose you know. But there were a lot of guys that recorded for Columbia like Miles Davis and Thelonious Monk, and that kind of thing. So I built a record collection that way.

MR: Do you recall when you started figuring out the mystery of chord symbols and how they might apply to your improvising?

RR: Yeah I do. When we got together to play it was just sort of a free for all you know. And I finally figured out oh, yeah, they're playing the form and there's a thing called a bridge you know. And you just don't stop playing until you wear out and stop. You actually follow this form. So yeah, that dawned on me and I started listening to music more intently and talking to my friends. And also at that time my dad would take me to hear guys that would come into town, like Oscar Peterson and Buddy DeFranco and Dizzy Gillespie, and so he would take me to these you know they were bars, nightclubs, and I'd get to hear these guys and that was good. My dad wasn't a musician or anything but he liked that music and so actually my mom would go too and sometimes my clarinet teacher would go — a clarinet teacher previous to the college one.

MR: I wonder if you ever had a private teacher that said to you — this would have been your classical teacher — that said, "Listen you have to choose. I can hear this jazz thing going

RR: No. They were pretty liberal. Yeah. They were pretty liberal even though they were straight ahead classical teachers and performers, they didn't give me a hard time about it. I think I mainly kept things separated. You know I mean I played Dixieland clarinet and all that kind of stuff, but I never really practiced that. I did all my legit stuff on clarinet and my jazz stuff on saxophone, so it was pretty much divorced.

MR: I gleaned a lot of wonderful information from your book which we'll get to. I understand the Vietnam war played a role in your decision about what direction to go when you were I guess late teens, early twenties?

RR: Yeah well actually I was a little older than that because I think that was — I went in the Army in 1967. And I was there for three years, '67 to '70. But yeah, I was going to get drafted. And I already had, well I was finishing up my master's degree at Michigan State and was getting ready to get married too. But my deferment, the day I got my degree, right after that I think it was on the weekend, on that Monday or Tuesday I got the "Welcome to the Army" draft notice. I went from 2S which was student, to 1A which was you're at the top of the list and you're going to get a physical. So I called a friend of mine who was in the West Point band and I said, "What's going on at West Point? What's going on there?" He says, "Oh it's really a good thing, it's 40 miles from New York and we go down and we take lessons in New York and work is not hard at all you've got a lot of free time and stuff and you go in as a rank of Sergeant and you get to stay there for three years." I said, "Well man, how do I get into that?" He says, "You've got to audition." He says, "I'll see if there are any spots, if there's going to be a spot coming up." So he did, he checked it out, and sure enough there was, they said, "Come on and audition here in June" after I got my degree. So I did, I went there and it was not like it is today where you see an ad in the *International Musician* and they say, "Opening for clarinet." It was more of not word-of-mouth so much but you had to be proactive and contact these different bands to find out if there was going to be anything coming up. And often they'd say no not yet, but I know there's going to be a couple of clarinet players — or whatever you played — you know getting out within six months so maybe there will be then. So anyway I auditioned and I was successful with that and got in, and so they cut your papers right there and then you go to the recruiter and say, "Here's where I'm going" you know and how do we do that. So you have to go through Basic Training. The only band that doesn't go through Basic Training is the Marine band. Everybody else has to go through Basic. And so you know, did that, and then I was at West Point for three years. But it was great because I was taking lessons from Leon Russianoff in New York and the Army was paying for it, and I was also taking flute lessons from Albert Regni who was a well known studio player and commercial player in

MR: I understand that you and some of your mates grew mustaches as a mild form of protest?

RR: Yeah we did. You've got to remember, in that era, you know that many young people did not think it was a good thing what we were doing in Vietnam. And also it was the idea of the draft and there was a lot going on and a lot of protests and marches and all kinds of stuff. And we kind of felt a little strange because we had real short haircuts and everybody else had long hair so immediately they know if we were in an area around West Point you know the surrounding area by twenty miles, they knew we were in the Army you know. So anyway yeah, you could have facial — well not a beard there. Maybe you could do it in the Navy but at that time you could only have mustaches. So we grew mustaches. And after a while the career people started thinking why are all these young guys growing mustaches? And you know they had to be trimmed a certain way, you couldn't go any longer than this and you certainly couldn't go down at all you know, it had to be — so yeah we had a surprise mustache inspection one day. We all had to go down and trim them up you know. But it was just our little thing of trying to, you know, say we're individuals.

MR: Well I'm glad your second trip overseas was not to go be in a war.

RR: Yeah.

MR: I wanted to ask you about Chuck Mangione. So I'm moving ahead a little bit and you're at Eastman and Chuck was well known locally. Was he doing like an adjunct at Eastman at that time?

RR: Yeah he was. When I went Rayburn Wright was also the first year that Ray Wright came, he came from Radio City Music Hall where he was the music director of that. He worked his way up through the arranging ranks and ended up as the head musical guy at Radio City. And he had been teaching some courses in the summer at Eastman, some arranging courses, called "The Arranger's Workshop." And he was then, thought it was time for him to move from the city and have a little less hectic life — not less busy though because you know you don't go to these jobs to try to retire because you're building things and you know working hard. But anyway he came to Eastman in 1970 and that was the first year that I was there. And I was assigned as his graduate assistant and so that turned out to be a very good thing. Now Chuck had been directing the jazz ensemble for the previous couple of years. He continued conducting the jazz ensemble during that time when Ray came, and Ray did all the arranging and those kinds of things and formed a studio orchestra which was the jazz ensemble with strings. And yeah, so Chuck was a formidable guy there. He was gaining recognition. By this time he had his first I don't know if it was his first one but the first one that kind of hit, that was a big production with strings and everything — I mean the concert was called "Friends and Love." So all

ensemble concerts and there'd be 3,000 people there. The Eastman Theater would be packed. And they weren't charging anything. Still, to get 3,000 people for a school show, you know, was pretty impressive. And so that happened and Chuck continued to gain popularity and because of that he started doing bigger records and doing some tours and I was lucky to play in his expanded group that did tours. We did tours of the East Coast and Midwest. He had me come to California once to do a recording there in Herb Alpert's, what is that A&R —

MR: A&M. Yeah.

RR: Yeah. So, yeah and I got to go back home and play in Red Rocks once. So Chuck, he liked me and he liked the things I could do. And because he liked friendly faces in the group you know, and if it was possible he would help people out. There were some other people I mean Jeff Tyzik played a lot of these tours too, and helped on a lot of the recordings.

MR: When he did his first "Friends and Love" and I think it was followed by "Together," what was — was there an attitude discernable from the Eastman Philharmonic about this young man who is coming in with these hand-written parts and bringing in an electric bass guitar and that kind of thing? How did that fly?

RR: Well those first two were done with the Rochester Philharmonic, which is not an Eastman thing, but it's an organization in its own right. Okay? But right, they were older, more experienced players and you know it's like anything you're going to have people that raise their nose and think it's, you know, beneath them. And then you're going to have the other people that are in favor of it you know. And it couldn't have been that much push-back because they were happy to take the money, okay? Happy to play the gig. And the records after that I think weren't done with them, it was done with other studio-type situations you know. But yeah, there was a little bit but not too much. But I've got to say, even when the jazz department put forth the first degree, it was a master's degree not a bachelor's, a master's in jazz performance. And two tracks: one in a performance and one in composition. All thought out and all the proper things that you're supposed to do for these things. But there had to be a faculty vote on it and there were some people that voted against it but it didn't pass you know. I mean it didn't fail. So yeah, there were some people around that think if you play jazz it's going to mess up your classical playing. And it doesn't. It's a different thing.

MR: It's rather stunning, the state of jazz education how it just sort of exploded over the years and now it's an integral part of almost any music school across the country.

RR: Yeah, it is. And also, the saxophone. I'll tell you, in the 1960s there were not many places you could study saxophone and get a degree. Joe Farrell — Monk, you know his name I

player. He was a flute major at Illinois. They didn't have saxophone. He couldn't major in saxophone, it was in flute.

MR: In fact, weren't you the first saxophone professor at Eastman?

RR: Yes. Well the first one with that title. There was a person teaching there who was on the clarinet faculty who also had several students — not many but a few, you know. And his name was Bill Ossick and he taught that. But I was the first one that had the title of Professor of Saxophone.

MR: And it was mostly classical I would imagine? Is that correct?

RR: It was, but they still had to take classical juries. But what we did, we did a lot of jazz you know. And many of those players from that period are extremely successful professional musicians. It didn't hurt them one bit. But then we got the master's degree doing. And there was straight jazz. And then after that came the bachelor's of jazz performance, or jazz composition. And so now we had these kind of two strings, or two streams, but I always just tried to teach the saxophone and then allow the students to decide what kind of music they wanted to play.

MR: When it came time to construct a four year curriculum for a jazz major, how many people were involved in those decisions about what courses are going to be required? What are things you can choose from? And what was really important? I imagine you were in the middle of that?

RR: Well yeah but that was quite a while ago. Thirty years probably you know. But I know it was figured out with mainly the three of us: Ray Wright, Bill Dobbins, and myself. Now those two guys were full time on the jazz side of things. I was teaching, you know, one-on-one saxophone lessons and clarinet to begin with and teaching ten hours of jazz which was an improvisation course and direct a band, that kind of thing. Probably a couple of courses, improv courses. So Ray and Bill mainly put it together with my input. And then outside of that we brought in people from the wind/brass/percussion department, you know like John Marcellus on trombone and the trumpet people, and the people that would be influenced, would be affected by this. And then we had to find some people who were sympathetic on rhythm section kind of instruments. Not that they would teach it but they just have to say hey that's okay and it's a thing to do and yes, it's fine. So we got friends and we talked to them and when it came time for, well I said the first time we had that undergrad thing not everybody voted for it. It wasn't unanimous but it got started. So the main thing is we started with a small group, expanded it out, made friends, and told them what we were doing. And by then the quality was really, really high. And you can't argue with that you know. If the example is extremely high and these guys were doing things — I mean the theory people would say man we love these jazz guys when they come in

know and then there was a couple of, at least one, musicologist — he was theory. But he was a pianist, an old jazz piano player that had done it. So he was really on top of it. He ended up teaching a course on Bill Evans that was very popular and really, really good. You know.

MR: I wish I could remember who said this to me but they pointed out that today's jazz major, instrumentalist, is much more likely to be able to step into a symphony gig and fill a part, rather than the other way around. That an orchestral musician would have much more trouble going playing Thad Jones/Mel Lewis charts.

RR: Yeah I think that's true, yeah, really. Definitely.

MR: I have a — speaking of previous interviews, I want to read something from two individuals and just get your reaction to it. This is from Phil Woods, and I was able to speak with him, probably — I've lost track — fifteen years or so. And I asked him about advice for young jazz men. And he said, "I think jazz is only for those that have no choice. I think if you're a young man and you're entertaining thoughts of becoming a brain surgeon or a jazz tenor man, I'd go with the brain surgery. If you've got two burning desires don't pick jazz. Don't rush into a jazz school or any university. I recommend taking a year off, hitchhike around the world, take your horn and see if you can play for your supper.

RR: Well that's very good advice, really. I think to be — if you just look at it you know you can start thinking pretty gloomy things about even being a music major let alone being a jazz musician. But the thing is that if you take what you do to the highest possible level and if you are successful being a really fine player, people recognize that and they will you know pay for you to play. But it's really tough, I mean some of the jazz guys going to New York nowadays, it's not $15 they're playing for but it's not much more. You know? Maybe $50 on some of the things you know just doing it to meet people and get started. I'm talking about guys right out of school. So I think what Phil was saying there was if you want to be a musician it has to call you and you can't think of doing anything else. It really has to be, this is it I'm doing it I'm going for it. You know.

MR: If you had a grandchild who wanted to do it, what would you say to them?

RR: I'd say to them — first of all to — I probably wouldn't even have to push this at all but know technology. Know what's going on and how the stage is now so much more than the town that you're in or the state that you're in or the country you're in. It's all over the world. And you know musicians find good work in Europe and in Asia. You know China is a good example. Jeez I had one guy that came — he went to Oberlin for his undergrad, and then he went to China. And he was in Shanghai for I think two or three years. Some of his other buddies were there. And they worked. They worked just playing American

experience playing and a very fine player and he got a master's degree here and he's now down in the D.C. area. But, yeah, he was thinking more of the world than just here, just what am I going to do? How can I get another job in Rochester? You know. Well you know maybe you've got to get the technology thing happening and become a very fine player, that's for sure.

MR: Now you spoke at length about that in this marvelous book that I'll —

RR: Oh yeah.

MR: And technology changes so fast that I see you brought on someone to help out with the second edition for that specific purpose.

RR: Yes, that's true.

MR: There was a couple of things in there that I really related to. You mentioned about there's no lack of great players, and you could have two people who you could hire that played equally well that could both fulfill the task, and you said, "Make sure you don't act like a jerk because no one's going to pick you even if you play really well."

RR: Well that's true. That's true. People recommend people who are good players and who are friends of theirs. It's just normal. You know why do you hire somebody and think that oh man, is this guy going to show up? You know. Or, will there be some incident that will happen? Or if he can go with the flow and, you know, not cause a scene. But there are, you mentioned earlier, before we started taping here, about Legos and Legos are things I talk about like things that you learn in life and how you take these Legos and you put them together and you build a career. And if you get to — the great thing about it is if you build something and then you say hmm, it's not looking too good, I need to build a little more over here, so you can craft this thing to fit you. Or you can knock the whole thing down and start over you know. But so to me Legos are things you can do. You know you can play certain pieces on your instrument, you gain experience playing in bigger ensembles in orchestras and that kind of thing. But there are also personality Legos that help you. And one of those things is being personable with, you know, with others.

MR: You have to learn how to hang.

RR: That's right. You've got to get the hang down.

MR: I think that should be a course at Eastman, Hang 101.

RR: Yeah. Boy I tell you when I was younger we used to — I could have taught it easily.

MR: Before I forget, I was looking at the course listing at Eastman for a four year degree and it reminded me of something Harry "Sweets" Edison said. I'm paraphrasing a little bit, nowadays it seems like musicians have their idols and they don't venture anyplace else. It's better to be the world's worst originator than the world's greatest imitator. So my

information the people from Sweets' generation over and over said everybody sounds the same. How do you think players can avoid that?

RR: Yeah, I think it's something you can't force you know. And you know if everybody is more or less doing, practicing the same stuff that's going to — I mean you get out what's put in and if you all are more or less inputting the same stuff through you, you know, the same play-a-long records, you know, that's how — well I mean it happens in America. I mean we can go into certain — we could be in Idaho someplace and go into a shopping mall and see the same stores there as we have here. So that's happening that way too. But I think what you do is have to forge your own, take your own background and experience and make that into something that's you. And that means being — I tell students — okay you're here at Eastman don't just have it be jazz, jazz, jazz all day. Know that there's world class singers that you can hear, you could hear — you know go to an opera, go to an orchestra concert, go to the new music people, go to the gamelan and check that stuff out. You know, you have to know — the, you know you have some scholarly kind of series that they have at school. And try to — I had one guy that was so really good, really into Cannonball and was just Cannonball, Cannonball, Cannonball. And I finally said, you've got to turn the page. You can't stay on this all the time. You know? You got it, go on to the next thing.

MR: I'm cracking up because if you look over my shoulder, I don't know if you can tell but that's Cannonball Adderley and he's been my guy. And I saw him actually in Rochester a number of times. I mean it's not the only person I listen to but for me he had everything I wanted from a saxophone player.

RR: Yeah. Well there's nothing wrong with that. Stan Getz was my guy you know.

MR: I wanted to ask you about some of the other Legos that you've been able to construct and — arranging and composing — can you tell me where, first of all let's talk about arranging. If you got a commission or you heard a tune that you wanted to arrange, let's say for jazz ensemble, how do you go about thinking of a different way to set it so that you're not just producing the original recording? Where do those thoughts come from?

RR: Well I don't know. I just start humming stuff, to tell you the truth. You know? What could it be? I can't think of an example off the top of my head right now, but you have to — there's got to be a reason that you do an arrangement. Let's say I get to choose the tune that I want to do. There's got to be a reason that I choose that tune. What am I going to bring to that tune that hasn't been done umpteen million times before? What can I do? So I think about it that way. Usually I'm thinking, I'm humming those type of things in my head before I get to — hey I think maybe I'll do an arrangement of that you know. I don't think first and find a title in something, although sometimes it happens. They say

fit the person who is asking for it. That's a difficult question. I don't know exactly how that goes.

MR: That's okay because I think that's sort of the magic of what makes people successful is they come up with things and they can't explain why but that's what makes them unique. Do you ever get ideas away from a piano or away from, okay I'm doing music now, but sometimes ideas may come at other times.

RR: Oh yeah. Oh yeah, just riding in the car or something you know, thinking of a bass line or something like that. I know people that try to write them down as soon as they can, they just have a little notebook of — in fact I kept a notebook for a long time just called "Ideas" and I'd just write stuff down where you know it could be a big band chart on so-and-so and stuff like that. And then I'd come back to that and look at it say oh yeah that could work and then I'd go ahead and sketch it out and go from there.

MR: You obviously were in the era of using score pads and I'm wondering if you transitioned to Finale or Sibelius? You know actually I was in a colleague of yours, Dave Rivello's music room and I was pleasantly surprised to see this big table with a huge pad on it and pencils. And he insisted it was important to do the physical act of putting a note on a piece of paper.

RR: Uh huh, yeah. Well I do it both ways. I sketch stuff and figure out things on the piano, and then I use Finale also and you know, put it in. And I got pretty good on Finale and pretty fast, like because every summer I'd go to Germany and I was in charge of the Eastman Philharmonia, they had a gig there playing in Heidelberg at a castle there. And I didn't have a piano so I had just the computer. And I edited a whole bunch of books and stuff, and I did a lot of editing for my publisher, Advance Music. And so I got pretty fast. But then I got more of an administrative job at Eastman around the year 2000 and it sort of worked into that a thing that I developed the Institute for Music Leadership and so I didn't write any music for a long time. And man I lost my chops. I had to come back to it. And by then Finale had moved on and I was still back here in like a stage coach you know, and they're driving cars you know. So you've got to keep your chops up there too.

MR: Indeed. Some of the odd — you mentioned putting strings — in your book — putting strings on a car commercial or something like that. I wonder if you have any memories of not necessarily terrible gigs but just oddball assignments that you might have taken on, working with producers or radio people, ad men, those kinds of things, and the odd things that they would ask for?

RR: All I can think of is one I remember, it was around Thanksgiving a long time ago and it was on the Friday, the day after Thanksgiving. And myself and Jeff Tyzik and a couple of other guys had to go down to New York at this real fancy place, fancy recording studio. I

And they were making a bumper, a little five second bumper that was going to be on ABC, you know, just a short little [scats] something like that. But out of that they were also writing a, they were going to take this bumper out of a longer piece. And so the rhythm section had already been done, okay? The tracks were there and we were the horns. And man we got going and this lady had her 12-year-old son there too and she started asking him things. I finally got the one thing from her, "I just want the feeling that I'm in my car in the convertible and I'm just driving a country road and the wind's in my hair and it's just a beautiful day." And we're banging our heads against — does that mean softer or louder? But we couldn't translate what was going on, even — it was ridiculous. One thing she said, she said, "Do you have a cello?" You know like do you see a cello in here? No. It was crazy.

MR: Meanwhile the clock is running, right?

RR: It was running for them, yeah, and for us you know. I mean we got paid well but they just didn't know.

MR: How about a gig that you played that either you recall as being the absolute Mount Everest of gigs, or the exact opposite. like this is such a train wreck?

RR: Oh I don't know. Let's see. I think some of things I did with Chuck were really good because there were so many people there. Like the Red Rocks concert was really good. Red Rocks in Colorado. And you know I made a special trip to be there to play that, or he had me come you know. And so that was really good just because of the electricity that was going on. And actually the other ones we did in various places with Chuck, we did them in big halls in Boston and New York, Carnegie Hall in New York, and D.C. So those things were very, very big. But I tell you, you know when things are really going I get the chills. I can feel it. And I've had it happen, you know, when I was directing the lab band at Eastman, the third band. You know? And when they were playing Jeez, I mean one concert I just wow, just got knocked out. When I was at Michigan State I had to have a scholarship in the fall, I had to play in the marching band. I remember one time in that stupid marching band, you know, just getting the chills, playing the stuff that we were playing for, you know, 80,000 people. So it happens, you know, like it happens when you play in a new orchestra you know just like playing "Miraculous Mandarin" by Bartok. I really get, mmm, this is great.

MR: Yeah, to sit in the middle of all that. I wonder if you've ever had the experience of playing specifically a saxophone in an orchestra? The reason I'm asking is this happened to me once. I believe the piece was by a fellow named Honneger. And there was an alto sax part and of course the part required you to sit there for probably 80 bars and then come in and of course it's a solo. And it wasn't the kind of music that you could just feel

where you are. Like is this measure 49 or is it 50 of my rests. Is this something that ever happened to you?

RR: Oh yeah. Yeah that's happened. But that's part of the deal. That happens in Rachmaninoff's Symphonic Dances you know the only thing the alto saxophone does is play a solo. It's in a bunch of sharps and you play it at about, I don't know, about ten minutes into the piece. So you're there, your reed is dried out, could have lost suction, you know you never know what's going to happen there. But I'll tell you one of the roughest things the "Pictures at an Exhibition" was written by Mussorgsky, okay? And it was the most famous version, the orchestration of it, is by Ravel. That's the one that everybody knows. And that's the one that has the big saxophone solo in it that's "The Old Castle." So the thing is this Mussorgsky piece has been arranged probably, well I think I heard the number 25 times. So one of the conductors, or our main conductor, had the idea we're going to do "Pictures at an Exhibition," but we're going to mix and match the various variations. And he took about four or five or maybe six composers and put them in. Okay so the saxophone, normally you play alto saxophone, nice melodic thing, it's a great solo. The part I had to play on soprano saxophone was a trumpet part and it goes like this [scats] that kind of thing like that, keep them going so on soprano sax I think it starts on a high C or something. And so I'm telling you, that was a killer. An absolute killer. And I was really nervous about that. But I blew it the first time around, I played it so fast. Because the trumpet players usually play it real fast. And I talked to the conductor and I said, "I'm sorry I got way ahead." And I said, "I thought we'd be going faster." And he said, "Oh the trumpets just like to play it fast to get through it." He said, "We're going to go slower." So anyway, that's a lot of pressure on you and that's the way it is.

MR: That whole mindset of playing exactly what someone else has written and being in the jazz world is, I don't have an exact comment except it's such as different way of being in your head.

RR: Yeah it is, but yeah, there's different rules. There's different rules. You know if you crack a note in a jazz thing it's not that big a deal you know. But you crack a note in the middle of a legit solo it's pretty big.

MR: I like the way you started your book, *Lessons from a Street-Wise Professor* with this bit about goals. And I remember being at Fredonia and the jazz guys were sort of their own club. And we all wanted to make it. And I remember that phrase but I don't remember being really aware of what that meant to us. We just wanted to make it. And you addressed that. Can you speak about that a little bit?

RR: Jeez I can't remember what I said about it.

MR: Well it was like what means the most to you? Making a lot of money? Working with underprivileged kids?

RR: Sure. What is the big deal for you. Well in my own case I'll just say that when I started off in college, I wanted to be a, I thought if I could teach a high school band in Denver that'd be the greatest thing in the world. And that's what I thought of doing. But it's along the way I met people and, you know, and one thing led to another. Another opportunity came up. But I think the thing, Monk, that you're referring to is that if you think you want to be, okay when you're first out of school playing on a cruise ship might be good. Okay? It might be fun. But you know when you're 55 years old or so and you're looking like oh wow man, I may retire in a while, it's not that cool. And so the — I think you know that you kind of move the goal post as you get, as you grow up and learn more and get more experience, and, you know, kind of adjust the rudder to make sure you're still moving ahead. I think the goal should be whatever really makes you happy. It could be finding a mate. You know? Hopefully that'll happen as well as finding a good job. You know? I'm sorry I'm not really zeroing in on it very well.

MR: That's fine. And the opportunities for graduating jazz musicians are obviously different than they were 20, 30 years ago.

RR: Yeah. Well they weren't great 20 or 30 years ago either. You know the thing I think is that if you've got many different things that you can do, and do at a high level, you can have more options, and that's the name of the game, you know, having some options. And jazz people, I mean I'd say 95 percent of people who call themselves jazz musicians also teach. It's just part of the deal you know. If you're going to be a jazz guy they generally write tunes too. And you know, know how to orchestrate them. So there'd be many things you can do just in that area. Your writing helps your playing and your playing helps your writing. It all goes together.

MR: And some of them still play "Girl from Ipanema" at dance gigs too.

RR: I know.

MR: It's so funny that, "You guys know anything Latin?" If you get a request, 90 percent of the time it's "Girl from Ipanema."

RR: Yeah, that's right.

MR: Which has to have the strangest bridge of any tune, at least that I know.

RR: Uh huh.

MR: So you wrote that you're kinda, sorta, retired.

RR: Yeah?

MR: How do you fill your time these days?

RR: Oh what I do is, if it's in the summer I'm working outside a whole lot. I've got a chain

everything. Because the gigs just stopped. And so I looked and Jeez it was a year and a half and I hadn't practiced anything. But then a couple of — one Broadway show is coming that I'm going to play. And it's just clarinet, and I thought okay that'll be good, I'll do this. It's "My Fair Lady." It's an old time thing, I mean old type of scoring, you know that has four woodwinds which you hardly — you never have anymore. You usually have one guy playing everything. So anyway I'm working on clarinet, you know, getting my chops back up and I'm helping a friend of mine, I'm playing through his — he's writing a soprano saxophone piece. And I'm playing through that and helping him out on it and you know doing those kinds of things. And then just general being retired. It's kind of nice.

MR: This might test your memory a little bit. You know the Stanley Theater in Utica?

RR: Yeah.

MR: Well I have an inside source that said you once played Santa at the Stanley Theater in Utica.

RR: I did. Yes. The clarinet playing Santa.

MR: Another Lego piece.

RR: Yeah another Lego piece. And not only that, once I conducted the Utica Symphony there. And I think it was a holiday concert. It was, it was a holiday concert. I guess they liked me so much as Santa they —

MR: You didn't know you were auditioning.

RR: No. But what's really interesting is I played that same place, it wasn't renovated at the time, but I played at the Stanley Theater with Chuck Mangione and it must have been with the Utica Symphony. But a whole bunch of us went down and played. And my wife was playing second oboe at the time. She was in high school. And she ended up being my wife. And so we didn't know but we were on the same stage in whenever it was, 1971, I don't know.

MR: That's wonderful. Well you've had a terrific career and I've enjoyed this conversation so much. And I wish you continued activity and creativity.

RR: That's the way to do it. Yeah. I'm still — I'm thinking of getting back, getting the old Finale going here and doing some stuff. I've got some ideas and things I want to try.

MR: Well I have a saxophone ensemble here who'd be glad to read anything you write.

RR: Okay. Well thanks very much for asking me, Monk, I appreciate it.

MR: Thanks. I'm going to sign off and then we'll say our good-byes.

RR: Okay.